

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 9



CHAPTER 9



ANCHOR TO WINDWARD

When it was time to close the chandlery for the night, Mr. Ropes and Mr. Hodges still had not returned. Nat closed the shop and went to supper, then climbed the stairs to his room. As he entered, a sudden thought struck him. Soon this wouldn't be his room. He'd go to live in Mr. Ward's house. Nat looked around the room that had been his home for five years. Suddenly his stomach felt hollow.

Someone rapped on the door; Mr. Hodges entered. "I saw Sam Ward," he said. "He told me he'd been in and talked to you."

"Yes, Mr. Hodges." Nat made himself smile again. "He said he'd bought you out — lock, stock, and book-keeper."

Mr. Hodges smiled briefly. "There's one thing, Nat — I suggested to Mr. Ward that you go on living here — if it's all right with you."

"Not leave this room?"

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"Unless you want to."

Nat turned quickly to the window and stared hard at the ships in the harbor. After a while he said, "That suits me fine. I've always liked this view."

Mr. Hodges said, "Good! We like having you here!"

It was July, and the summer doldrums had settled over the chandlery. Nat was deep in his Latin when Lizza's voice called from the door, "May I come in?"

"Of course, Lizza!" Nat got up quickly and went to meet her, grinning. "You know what? Every year since you were eight, you've gotten twice as pretty as you were the year before."

"Hmmm . . . " Lizza bit her tongue and rolled her eyes. "I'm nineteen now . . . eight from nineteen . . . " She sighed. "You mathematician! I wish you could at least pay a compliment without arithmetic! Eight from nineteen is eleven. Twice as pretty every year . . . Goodness, I'm twenty-two times as pretty!"

Nat laughed. "You're two thousand and forty-eight times as pretty. Keep count on your fingers as I double one eleven times: two — four — eight — sixteen — thirty-two — sixty-four — one hundred twenty-eight — two hundred fifty-six — five hundred twelve — one thousand and twenty-four — and two thousand and forty-eight!"

"And next year . . ." Lizza said.

"Four thousand and ninety-six times as pretty! And now tell me — what's making that frown between your eyebrows?"

"I'm worried about David Martin and Mary. Did you know David wants to marry her?"

Nat blinked. "But don't you like David?"

"Of course! He's grand! But Mary says she won't marry a sailing man!" Lizza's eyes flashed. "Can you imagine that? Five generations of sea captains in her blood, and she won't marry a sailor!"

"Maybe that's why she feels that way," Nat said. "Remember what you told me once? Sometimes women get a little upset about the sea. Or maybe Mary saw that item in the paper about Marblehead. It's a sailing town, too — with about 6000 people; and 459 widows and 865 orphans."

Lizza nodded. "I think that's what upset her. She just feels she can't marry a sailor and spend most of her life wondering where he is, how he is, and if he'll ever get home safely again. But, Nat, she *loves* David."

"You want me to talk to Mary?"

"Please," Lizza urged. "She'll listen to you. She says you have the brains of the family — you and William. Of course . . ."

Nat grinned. "It's just about mathematics? That's all right, I'll explain it to her mathematically — you know — two plus two — and things like that."

That evening Nat went to see Mary. He didn't beat around the bush. "I heard that David Martin wants to marry you?"

Mary looked up quickly from the hank of yarn she was winding into a ball. "What did he say to you?"

"Nothing. How do you feel about marrying a sailor?"

Mary said, "I won't."

"Good enough," Nat said. "I'll see that David stops bothering you. After all, there are plenty of other girls. I think Hester Githens' would marry David in a minute.

I'll mention her to David — get him interested — ”

“Nat Bowditch! Don't you dare tell David — ”

“No trouble at all,” Nat said. “That's what brothers are for — to take care of their sisters. I'll see David tomorrow. I'll talk about Hester — get him interested. In no time at all, he'll fall in love and marry her. Then, the next time he goes to sea, you won't have to worry about what happens to him.”

Mary jumped up, spilling her yarn. Her eyes snapped the way Granny's used to, but dimples were fighting to show around her mouth. “Nat Bowditch! You get out of here before I throw something!”

Nat grinned. “I'm not afraid. I was just going anyway.”

The night after Mr. and Mrs. David Martin moved into their little home, their friends gathered for a housewarming. Nat got there late. He poked his head in the door.

"Do I dare come in?"

Mary ran to meet him with a hug and a kiss. "Always! I don't know why, but David seems to think you're quite a man! He said if I ever had trouble with you, I'd swing from a yardarm!"

Nat laughed and went to find Lizza. Lizza was in the corner, telling a story to a girl of ten or eleven — a youngster with a mop of black curls and a face that seemed all violet eyes. Nat recognized her; she was Captain Boardman's little daughter, Elizabeth. He smiled at them. "The two Elizabeths!"

The youngster's eyes sparkled. "We do have the same name, don't we? Only I wish someone had nicknamed

me 'Lizza,' too. How did Lizza ever get that name?"

Lizza said, "I think Nat called me that when he was too little to talk plain."

Elizabeth studied Nat gravely. "Funny to think you were young once, isn't it? I suppose you seem older because of your brains. People say figures just run out of your ears. But I don't see any." Then, in a swift change of mood, she said, "Mary will be awfully happy here, won't she? I mean — she knows how to be happy. Being happy takes a lot of practice, don't you think?"

Lizza said, "Go tell David that, Elizabeth. He'll love it."

When Elizabeth had gone, Nat whistled softly. "How do you keep up with her?"

Lizza smiled. "She's a dear child. But she does say the oddest things. Sometimes I think she must have been born knowing them. I tell her she has eyes in the back of her heart."

Nat smiled. "And *she* says odd things? I think you're quite a pair."

When Nat got back to his room that night it seemed emptier and more lonely than it had at any time since his first night there, five years ago. He sat down and tried to study, but the words meant nothing. He went to the window and watched the moon follow her path through the stars. Some day, when he had translated all of Newton, he'd know more about why the moon followed that certain path through the heavens.

He remembered his mother's words: "I made a sort of saying for myself, Nat: *I will lift up my eyes unto the stars. . . .*"

Finally Nat turned and went back to his work.

The months passed, and winter came again. One day the Reverend Dr. Prince dropped in at the chandlery and asked, "How's Newton coming along, Nat?"

"I think I'll make quite a career of Newton," Nat told him. "At the rate I'm going, it will take me about ten years to read *Principia*. First, I have to figure out what it means in English, and then I have to figure out what it *means*."

Dr. Prince shook his head. "Why you keep at it I'll never know. But it will go faster after a while, Nat."

A year later, one raw December day, Dr. Prince was in the chandlery again. "How's Newton coming now?"

"Better!" Nat told him. "I think it's only going to take me five years now."

Dr. Prince shook his head again.

Elizabeth Boardman came into the chandlery, her eyes sparkling. "Here's a note for you, from Lizza, Nat. I'm to wait for an answer, please."

Nat excused himself and read the note. Lizza and Mary were planning a party to surprise David — the ninth of December. Could Nat be there, sure? Nat smiled at the postscript: "Shhh! It's a secret! Tear this note across eleven times and scatter the 2048 pieces to the wind!"

Nat said, "Tell Lizza the answer is yes. I'll be there."

Dr. Prince smiled at the youngster. "Elizabeth, maybe you can figure this out for me. Why do you think Nat reads Latin?"

Elizabeth rolled her eyes gravely from one to the other. "It's his brain, don't you think? I mean — it's awfully restless. He probably reads Latin to keep it quiet. The way girls stitch samplers, you know."

Dr. Prince blinked. When Elizabeth had gone, he started out, too, still shaking his head. He turned back, "I'm even forgetting why I came. Can you see me to-night, Nat, after you close? I've something to show you."

When Nat reached Dr. Prince's home that night, he was waiting in his study. "I don't know whether you've ever heard of it, Nat, but we have a special library here — The Salem Philosophical Library. A group of us started it about ten years ago. We've been adding to it, year after year. Now, I think we have the best scientific library between here and Philadelphia. You may never have heard of it — since it's a private library. Only members can use it."

"How much does it cost to be a member, sir?"

Dr. Prince said, "About fifty pounds."

Nat's hopes sank. Years yet before he'd be free. And even then he'd have nothing.

"I've been talking to the members, Nat. We have decided to make an exception in your case; you're to be allowed to read the books. If you'd like to . . . Would you like to, Nat?"

Nat struggled to swallow the lump in his throat. "Yes, sir. More than anything in the world."

"Good!" Dr. Prince nodded toward the shelves. "Help yourself." He turned to the papers on his desk and began working.

Nat opened one of the books and read the name on the flyleaf. He asked, "This Richard Kirwan — is he a member of the library?"

Dr. Prince looked up from his work. "Kirwan? No, he's a great Irish scientist. We started this collection with one hundred and sixteen books from his private library.

That was during the war. The books were part of the cargo of a prize ship — the *Mars*. She struck her colors to a privateer of ours — the *Pilgrim*. Some day I'll tell you the story." He bent over his work again.

Nat stared at the book, smiling. The *Pilgrim*! These were the books captured on the *Mars* and auctioned off to Dr. Stearns! He chose a book, wrote the name of it on the pad of paper, thanked Dr. Prince again, and went back to his room. Before he started reading, he wrote a note:

Notice to Lizza:

Be it known by these presents that on this day Nathaniel Bowditch started collecting his expectations on the *Pilgrim*. He's having a chance to read the "finest scientific library between here and Philadelphia." P.S. Shhh! This is secret! Tear this note across twelve times and scatter the four thousand and ninety-six pieces to the wind! N.B.

He grinned as he folded the note. When he saw Lizza at the party, he'd give it to her. He put it in his coat pocket so he would not forget it.

From downstairs came faint sounds of confusion. Then feet thudded on the steps and David Martin called, "Nat! Nat!"

Nat jerked the door open.

David stood a moment panting and then spoke in gasps. "Lizza . . . she fell on the stairs . . . it's pretty bad . . . the doctor says . . . you'd better come!"

That night, and the days and nights that followed, were a nightmare of fighting to save Lizza. Nat was by her, holding her hand, when she died.

The night after the funeral Nat walked alone out on the wharf. He shivered, thrust his hands in his pockets, and found the note he'd written Lizza. Slowly he tore it to bits and scattered the pieces on the water. He watched the ebbing tide carry them out until they sank. He thought of Tom Perry and the note they'd scattered on the water in his memory. He could almost hear Lizza's whisper again: "If you squinch your eyes, Nat, it looks exactly like flowers — almost — doesn't it?"

Nat clenched his hands and stared at the water until it blurred. He looked up at the sky. The stars blurred, too. "I don't see any help in the stars! Not now!"

Behind him, someone spoke. "Nat?"

Nat wheeled and saw David. He snapped, "What do you want?"

"Mary sent me. She was worried."

Nat spoke harshly. "She needn't worry. Tell her I've gone home to read Latin. It's good for restless brains — keeps them quiet, like stitching samplers." He shoved past David and left the wharf.

David fell in step beside him. Silent, they walked out toward the Beverly Ferry — then turned and tramped back across town toward Gallows Hill. There was no sound but the crunch of their feet in the snow.

At last Nat turned toward Hodges' house. When they got there, he held out his hand. "I'm sorry, David. Give Mary my love. Good night."

David said, "I'll tell her about the Latin. It sounds like a good anchor to windward. People that can use their brains are lucky. You'll never abandon ship, Nat."

In his room, Nat opened the Kirwan book again. He

tried to read, but the words made no sense. He opened a new notebook and began to copy an article, a word at a time, saying each word aloud as he wrote it.

When dawn came, he was writing swiftly, filling page after page with his fine scrawl. When he realized it was light, he took off his clothes, washed, dressed again, and went to the chandlery.

He was busy with the bellows, trying to coax the embers of the fire into flame, when the door opened and a gust of wind whipped through the shop.

Without looking up he snapped, "Shut the door, can't you?"

"I'm trying!" a girl's voice gasped.

Nat jumped to his feet and turned. Elizabeth Boardman was struggling to close the door.

Nat flinched. If she mentions Lizza's name, he told himself, I'll bite her head off, and then she'll bawl . . . He groaned and hurried to close the door.

"Thank you, Nat!" Elizabeth sighed and brushed back a curl with a dust-begrimed hand.

Nat looked at her grimy hands, her soot-streaked face. "Where in the world have you been? And what are you doing out this time of morning?"

"I brought you something." She handed him a packet, carefully wrapped in white paper — with her grimy fingerprints on it. "I'm sorry it's dusty. It was in the store-room. Will you open the door, please, and shut it after me? I have to get home before anyone wakes up and misses me."

Before Nat could collect his wits, she was gone.

He unwrapped the package. It was a book — in Latin.